

ASIAN FIREARMS (1650–1780)

Firearms arrived in Japan in 1543 with Portuguese traders who had traveled from their base in India. The Japanese initially resisted the use of gunpowder weapons, preferring their traditional bows and swords, but eventually saw the advantages of a coordinated use of matchlock muskets in battle, notably at Sekigahara in 1600. Until the late 19th century, Japanese muskets retained the Portuguese snap-matchlock design, a mechanism in which the serpentine was held back by a catch and fell forward under spring pressure when a user pulled the trigger. Matchlock muskets in other parts of Asia varied in style between regions although the matchlock used was the squeeze-type (see p.74). In India, matchlock guns had been present from as early as 1531, when the Ottomans used them against the Portuguese in the Siege of Diu.

